Connect the Dots
A map of co-occurring conditions

Neurodivergent Pain Scale

This one goes to 11

"Rate your pain out of 10" assumes we can map what we feel to a number. That requires calibrated interoception, a shared reference frame, and a meaningful zero. None of which are guaranteed for neurodivergent people or those with chronic pain.

This scale replaces "pick a number" with "which description matches?"

How to use: Find the description that matches right now and point to it. The *italic notes* are for clinicians.

CLINICAL RATING	WHAT I'M EXPERIENCING	ND RATING
0	**No pain** My body feels neutral. I'm not aware of any pain. *A genuine zero may be unfamiliar with chronic pain.*	–1
1	**Hardly noticeable** My pain is barely there. I'm only aware of it if I pay attention. *Low interoception may mean this level isn't registered at all.*	0
2	**Noticeable** I'm aware of my pain but I can ignore it most of the time. *Alexithymia may make this hard to label , "something's off" rather than "pain."*	1
3	**Mild** My pain bothers me but I can ignore it most of the time. *Often where the chronic baseline sits. May report "I'm fine" because this is normal.*	2
4	**Moderate** My pain bothers me. I can still do most activities but I'm aware of it throughout. *May register as fatigue or brain fog rather than "pain."*	3
5	**Can't ignore it** My pain is always there. Everything takes more effort. I'm starting to adjust around it. *Masking may keep the face neutral. May still say "I'm okay."*	4
6	**Dominating attention** My pain is the loudest thing in my head. It's making me tired. I'm dropping everything that isn't essential. *May drop suddenly from "fine" to unable. Stimming may increase.*	5
7	**Functioning with effort** I can do essential things, but each one costs too much. I need to lie down between tasks. Some care activities are no longer doable. *May go nonverbal. Can look like "shutdown," not "in pain."*	6
8	**Functioning breaking down** I can't think clearly. I can't follow conversation or make decisions. Sleep is wrecked. All activities require pacing. *An ND "7" may look like someone else's "4." Masking persists under extreme pain.*	7
9	**Severely limited** Getting up, washing, eating feel monumental. Care activities are being sacrificed. Social and work activities can't be tolerated. *May be still and silent. The quiet patient may be in the most pain.*	8
10	**Overwhelming** Speaking is difficult. I can barely move. Nothing provides relief. *May still answer questions on autopilot. "You seem fine" is not an assessment.*	9
10+	**Worst imaginable** I can't move from where I am. Nothing touches the pain. I can't ask for help. *Beyond what the standard scale measures.*	10
10++	**Beyond the scale** I've dissociated. Words have stopped working. I may not remember this afterward. *If this point is reached, it's likely every prior rating was under-reported.*	11

This is a communication tool, not a diagnostic instrument. It's designed to help you describe your experience to a clinician in terms that are more accessible than a numeric scale. It does not replace clinical assessment. If you are in severe pain, seek medical attention.

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